
Filtering the Emperor: Communication Networks around Maximilian I (1459-1519)

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Abstract

This paper re-examines Manfred Hollegger’s notion of the ”Hecke”, a ‘hedge’ of counsellors surrounding Emperor Maximilian I, using formal network analysis. Our research questions to what extent this Hecke can be quantitatively reconstructed or formally defined when we model the emperor’s entourage with data from heterogeneous historical sources. Our data are drawn from the ”Managing Maximilian” project, which is building a prosopographical database in an interdisciplinary collaboration among Austrian universities, research institutes and museums. The corpus is still expanding (Sagadin et al., 2026), and the analysis presented here is based on a current version of the database, meaning that the results should be considered as a reproducible baseline for future experiments and data enrichment.

The platform (Hadden, 2022) encodes persons, institutions and their interactions extracted from several source types, including charters, correspondence, financial records and administrative documents. Rather than smoothing over their heterogeneity, we exploit it as a methodological resource, extracting and analysing the networks coming from different types of interactions among people mentioned in the sources.

In previous work (Tambuscio 2025), we showed that modelling typed interactions instead of simple co-occurrences reveals distinct roles and dynamics at Maximilian’s court, even on a limited corpus. Building on this approach, we are developing focused analyses of ego-networks and temporal slices in several modelling frameworks, in order to study the evolution of network measures over time and space.

Inspired by Hollegger’s interpretation of the ”Hecke” as a flexible group of counsellors and intermediaries around the Emperor, we consider subnetworks built directly from interaction types that reflect communication and transfers, such as correspondence, payments and orders. These relations are particularly relevant because they capture not only the proximity to the emperor, but also mediation and access.

Methodologically, we apply k-core decomposition combined with centralities to identify actors embedded in dense communicative structures: a node belongs to the k-core if it is connected to at least k other nodes that are themselves part of the same core. Preliminary results show that two members of the Hecke mentioned by Hollegger (Matthäus Lang and Zyprian von Serntheim) appear in the maximum k-core (k=6) of the current communication network and also occupy relevant brokerage positions in the complete activity network. Paul

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von Liechtenstein, mentioned as well by Holleger, is, by contrast, present in the dataset but does not belong to the maximum k-core. We interpret this discrepancy cautiously: it may partially reflect uneven temporal and documentary coverage because the currently integrated sources do not represent all phases of the actors' careers with the same level of detail. Then the absence of Paul Von Liechtenstein may be due to incompleteness of the data collection rather than a substantial absence from Maximilian's close environment: his career was strongly connected with Tyrol and South Tyrol, and several relevant archival holdings concerning this regional context still need to be integrated into the platform. At the same time, the opposite bias is also possible. Actors for whom scholars have already entered a particularly rich body of data, such as Niklas Ziegler, may appear structurally more prominent because they are better documented in the current state of the database. The present network should therefore be read as a work-in-progress model of archival visibility, not as a definitive reconstruction of the emperor's inner circle.

In this framework, the analysis is deliberately provisional and shows how network analysis, grounded in careful source criticism and explicit modelling choices, can be used to examine and test historiographical concepts of informal power at court.

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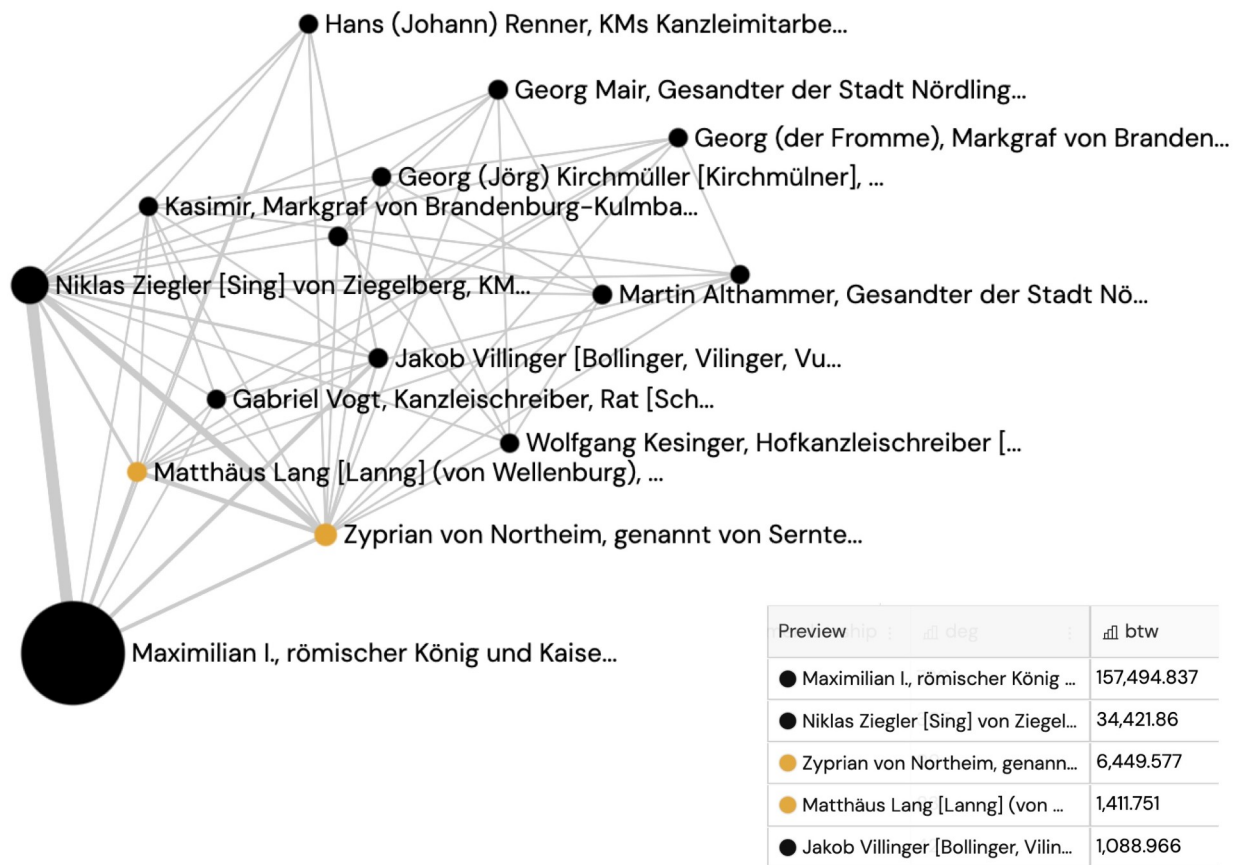


Figure 1. K-core decomposition and the list of top5 brokers revealing a denser inner structure. People mentioned by Hollegger are highlighted in orange.

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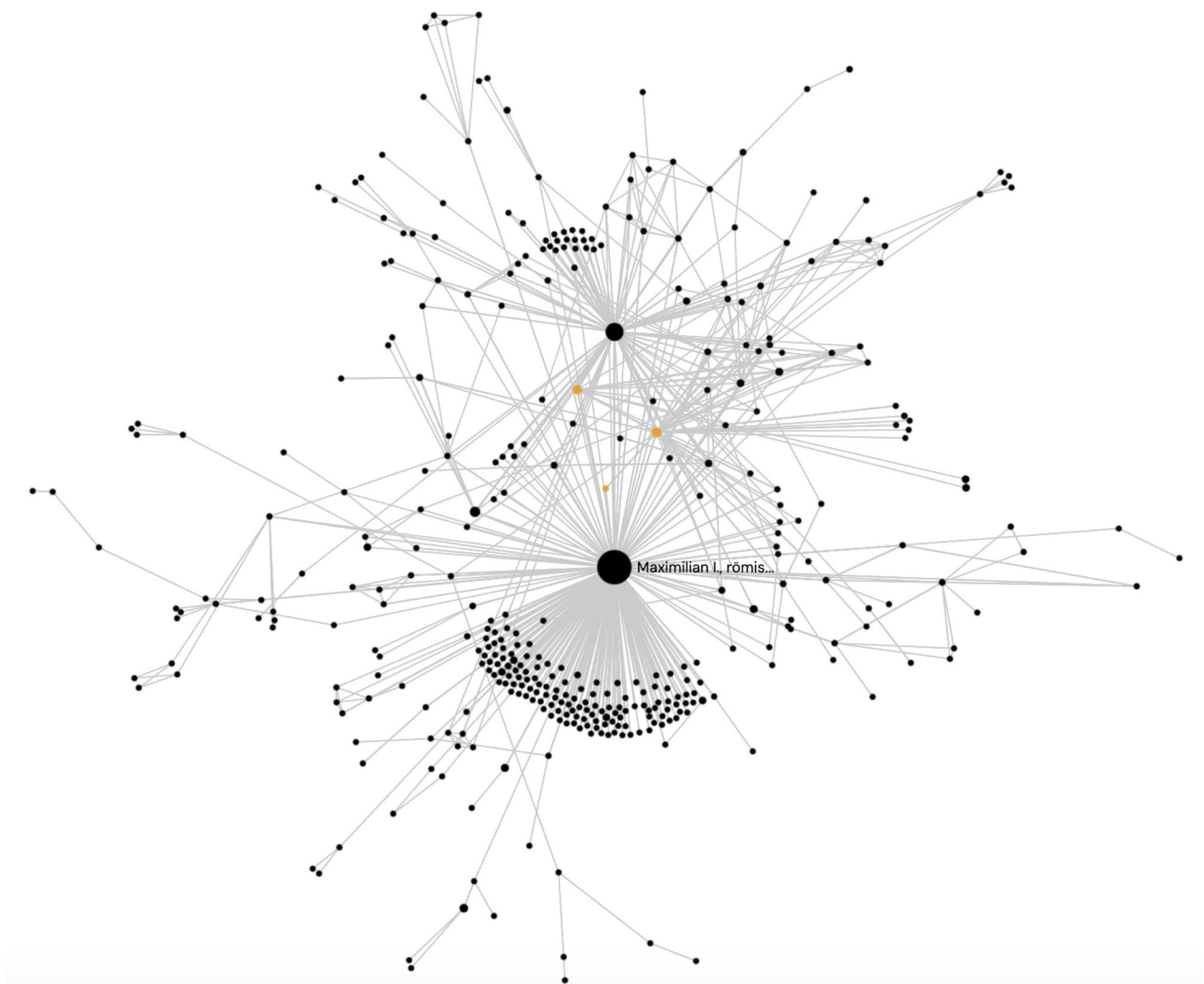


Figure 2. Communication network around Maximilian